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Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, MARCH 25, 2025 • \$4

Off to the Sweet 16



HANNAH FOSLIEN/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Sarah Te-Biasu and her Maryland teammates won the game of the NCAA women’s basketball tournament Monday night in College Park, finding their way past Alabama, 111-108, in double overtime. Te-Biasu scored 26 points for the fourth-seeded Terrapins, who will face defending champion South Carolina in the round of 16. *More in Sports, D1*

DOGE struggling to turn up Social Security fraud

BY TODD C. FRANKEL
AND HANNAH NATANSON

Elon Musk put a big target on the Social Security Administration in the first weeks of the Trump administration, claiming it is plagued by “immense waste” and promising audits to root out “the extreme levels of fraud.” President Donald Trump said during his joint address to Congress earlier this month that

Musk’s claims of massive waste at agency are at odds with audits, reports

Musk’s U.S. DOGE Service was already “identifying shocking levels of incompetence and probable fraud” at the agency. But some of the biggest exam-

ples of allegedly wasteful spending held up by Musk and DOGE so far have been overblown or inaccurate. Musk’s assertion that tens of millions of dead people over 100 years old are receiving Social Security benefits was so off-base that it had to be tamped down by the agency’s acting head, who had been promoted because of his willingness to cooperate with DOGE. “These individuals are not necessarily

receiving benefits,” acting Social Security commissioner Lee Dudek said.

Musk’s intense focus on Social Security appears central to his promise to slash \$2 trillion from the federal budget. The agency distributes \$1.6 trillion in benefit payments each year, making up

SEE SOCIAL SECURITY ON A7

Probationary workers: Trump asks high court to allow firings. **A4**

Oz may face conflict over benefits company

Firm he has ties to could profit from his leadership of agency, experts say

BY LAUREN WEBER
AND CAITLIN GILBERT

Mehmet Oz, the nominee to run the Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services, co-founded health benefits company ZorroRX with his son last year, according to now-hidden source code and a blog post on the company’s website. ZorroRX and similar companies promise to make hospitals money and save employers cash by connecting patients to the federal 340B Drug Pricing Program.

That program is designed to help hospitals get a deal on prescription drugs with the government intention that profits could be passed on to patients in underserved and underinsured communities.

But as use of the government drug pricing program has exploded, health-care analysts say the unregulated system has driven up health-care costs and is not helping vulnerable patients, all

SEE OZ ON A4



JONATHAN NEWTON/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Larry DeSantis exited the Key Bridge at 1:24 a.m. on March 26, 2024. It collapsed at 1:29.

A year ago, he drove over Baltimore’s Key Bridge. Minutes later, it collapsed.

Larry DeSantis needed to get to his second job.

That’s what he was thinking as he drove toward Baltimore’s Francis Scott Key Bridge a year ago, on March 26, in his gray Toyota pickup.

His shift in the bakery at the Green Valley grocery store, where he makes the marshmallow doughnuts and sourdough rolls, had ended at 1 a.m., and he was scheduled to start at Herman’s Bakery in Dundalk at 1:45 a.m. He

Larry DeSantis’s truck was one of the last to cross the span before the Dali container ship struck it

BY MICHAEL LARIS

stopped in the parking lot to chat with a colleague for a few minutes, time that seemed insignificant then but would later matter. He then drove the familiar route toward the Patapsco River, where he used to troll for rockfish. When he got to the bridge, he noticed a massive container ship in the water below but saw it as part of the stunning panorama he had come to expect on his commute.

SEE BRIDGE ON A18

Officials discussed military planning in unclassified chat

EDITOR ACCIDENTALLY ADDED TO TEXT CHAIN

Democrats decry use of unsecured messaging app

This article is by Dan Lamothe, Michael Birnbaum, Abigail Hauslohner, Warren P. Strobel and Ellen Nakashima

Top officials in the Trump administration discussed highly sensitive military plans using an unclassified chat application that mistakenly included a journalist, the White House acknowledged Monday, a development that swiftly drew criticism from Democrats and Washington’s national security establishment.

Brian Hughes, a spokesman for the White House National Security Council, said the message thread revealed in an extraordinary report by the Atlantic’s editor in chief, Jeffrey Goldberg, “appears to be authentic,” and that administration officials were “reviewing how an inadvertent number was added to the chain.”

The “inadvertent number” belonged to Goldberg, whose article details a robust policy discussion that occurred in the lead-up to a March 15 military operation targeting Yemen’s Houthi militants. Goldberg reported being added to

the group chat, which occurred on the encrypted messaging platform Signal, by President Donald Trump’s national security adviser, Michael Waltz. Other participants appeared to include Vice President JD Vance, Secretary of State Marco Rubio, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, Director of National Intelligence Tulsi Gabbard, CIA Director John Ratcliffe and several other senior aides, the Atlantic article says.

Hughes, the National Security Council spokesman, characterized the discussion as “a demonstration of the deep and thoughtful policy coordination between senior officials” executing Trump’s national security strategy. But the disclosure immediately raised questions about how the administration has discussed classified national security matters and whether anyone will be disciplined.

Senior Trump administration officials have warned in recent days that they will investigate unauthorized leaks to journalists, citing reporting in a number of

SEE LEAK ON A9

U.S. cuts in Africa leave opening for rival powers

Russia and China likely to increase strategic ties, if not humanitarian aid

BY KATHARINE HOURELD
AND ROBYN DIXON

President Donald Trump’s withdrawal of tens of billions of dollars in U.S. global aid spending has rapidly diminished key elements of America’s presence in Africa — upending long-standing programs, severing sensitive relationships and leaving a void that rival powers are keen to exploit.

Washington’s vanishing largesse and declining influence could further imperil stability in the region as governments turn increasingly to China and Russia, according to some analysts and

former U.S. officials. America’s two most powerful adversaries have been strengthening military and economic ties across Africa in recent years and investing heavily in media initiatives to counter Western narratives.

“You’ve heard over and over again that nature abhors a vacuum; if we are not engaged, someone else will be,” Gen. Philip Breedlove, a former supreme allied commander of NATO, told The Washington Post. “There are lots of countries that have lots more nefarious goals when they go out and engage.”

Secretary of State Marco Rubio announced this month that 83 percent of programs administered by the U.S. Agency for International Development were being eliminated, saying in a post that tens of billions of dollars had been spent “in ways that did not serve,

SEE AFRICA ON A12

Democrats appear open to pipeline they opposed

Rising energy costs drive support for Trump plan on Northeast gas project

BY EVAN HALPER
AND MAXINE JOSELOW

A decade ago, Democratic governors in New England cheered the demise of a plan to pipe natural gas from the shale fields of western Pennsylvania to population centers across the Northeast. But now, as President Donald Trump seeks to bring the project back from the dead, anxiety over energy costs has state leaders rethinking their opposition.

Electricity prices in the Northeast are 40 percent higher than the

national average, federal data shows. Bowing to pressure from constituents fed up with higher utility bills and worried that cheap renewable energy is not coming online fast enough, some of the region’s Democratic governors are now signaling an openness to negotiating with Trump on the project, known as the Constitution Pipeline.

In New York, where regulators played a key role in initially killing the pipeline, Gov. Kathy Hochul (D) spoke with Trump this month at the White House about the possibility of reviving it. In Connecticut, which has aggressive goals for moving its power grid off fossil fuels, Gov. Ned Lamont (D) recently met with senior Trump administration officials about bringing more gas to the state. And in

SEE PIPELINE ON A18

IN THE NEWS

Legislative immunity Arizona lawmakers’ invocations of a constitutional shield when facing speeding tickets are under scrutiny. **A8**

The laugh’s on them As Conan O’Brien was roasted at the Kennedy Center as the Mark Twain Prize recipient, President Donald Trump was also torched. **C1**

THE NATION
Three large wildfires are menacing a North Carolina county. **A3**
Prosecutors began laying out the corruption case against Nadine Menendez, wife of ex-senator Bob Menendez. **A3**

THE WORLD
Europe is investing millions in efforts to lure American scientists to its universities. **A13**
Russia downplayed U.S. hopes for rapid progress in talks on the Ukraine war. **A13**

THE ECONOMY
Fears regarding academic independence are rising in the wake of Columbia’s compliance with the Trump administration’s demand for policy changes. **A14**
Delete your DNA from 23andMe right now, columnist Geoffrey A. Fowler writes. **A14**

THE REGION
A violence interrupter was arrested in the 2023 shooting of a former Morgan State basketball player in D.C. **B1**
Virginia Gov. Glenn Youngkin (R) unveiled his proposed budget changes, teeing up a battle with the legislature’s Democratic majority. **B1**

STYLE
On Truth Social, Trump criticized his presidential portrait commissioned to hang in the Colorado Capitol. **C1**

HEALTH & SCIENCE
The writer of the “Medical Mysteries” column shares advice gleaned from the stories of more than 200 patients. **E1**

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